

CLASS 9 SOCIAL SCIENCE – HISTORY

Chapter 4: Early Humans and Beginning of Civilisation

Mid-Term Examination Notes

Detailed, crisp and topic-complete revision notes based on the new Class 9 SST chapter.

1. The Beginning of Human History

Human history is much older than written history. Humans and their ancestors lived on Earth for millions of years before writing was invented.

The period before writing is mainly studied through archaeological evidence. Writing developed at different times in different parts of the world.

More than 99% of human history belongs to the period before the last few thousand years. Studying this period helps us understand how humans developed their present way of life.

2. Early Writing Systems

Sindhu lipi: The pictographic script used by the Harappans on seals, pottery and other objects. It remains undeciphered.

Cuneiform: An early writing system used in Mesopotamia, especially by the Sumerians. It has been deciphered.

Hieroglyphics: The pictorial writing system of ancient Egypt. It has been deciphered.

Brahmi: A major early Indian script, used in parts of India from around 400 BCE and prominent in Ashokan inscriptions in the 3rd century BCE.

3. Why Study Early Human History?

Biological evolution means gradual physical and genetic changes through which early human ancestors developed into modern humans.

Cultural evolution means the gradual development of human tools, technologies, social practices and ways of adapting to the environment.

Changing climate and environments during the Quaternary Period encouraged humans to develop new tools and technologies.

4. How Do We Know About Early Humans?

Because early humans left no written records, archaeologists study material remains.

Stone tools reveal technological abilities and activities.

Fossils reveal physical characteristics and evolution.

Animal bones provide evidence about food, hunting and environment.

Pottery and objects reveal cooking, storage and crafts.

Cave and rock paintings provide clues about animals, hunting, art and surroundings.

Archaeologists can reproduce ancient tools experimentally to understand how they were made and used.

5. Human Ancestors and Migration

Early human ancestors evolved in Africa. Early settlements later spread through Africa, Asia and Europe, the 'Old World'.

Hominins include modern humans and their early human-like ancestors.

Homo erectus was an upright/bipedal human ancestor and is associated with an early migration out of Africa.

Humans migrated because of interacting factors such as food and water availability, climate, animal movement, population pressure and the search for suitable environments.

Modern humans (Homo sapiens) evolved in Africa around 300,000 years ago and later spread across most of the world.

6. Tools as 'Extra-Corporal Limbs'

Tools extended the abilities of the human body. Stone tools could cut meat, break bones, dig, scrape skins and extract marrow.

This is why tools can be described as 'extra-corporal limbs'—they allowed humans to perform tasks more effectively than bare hands could.

7. The Stone Age

The Stone Age is the long period when humans extensively used stone tools.

Palaeolithic: Old Stone Age.

Mesolithic: Middle Stone Age.

Neolithic: New Stone Age.

Later developments included the Chalcolithic, Bronze Age and Iron Age.

8. Palaeolithic Age – Old Stone Age

The Palaeolithic was the earliest and longest Stone Age phase. People mainly lived as hunter-gatherers and depended on naturally available plants, fruits, roots, fish and animals.

Important tools included choppers, handaxes, cleavers and scrapers. Quartzite and limestone were commonly used in many early contexts.

Tools were used for cutting meat, digging tubers, scraping skins, breaking bones and extracting marrow.

Important Indian sites: Attirampakkam (Tamil Nadu) and Isampur (Karnataka). Isampur is about 1.2 million years old and has evidence of stone-tool manufacture.

9. Development of Palaeolithic Technology

Tool technology became more varied and specialised. Later tools included scrapers, borers and points.

Humans later developed bows and arrows, parallel-sided blades, microblades and burins.

Beads made from stone, bone and shell, pigments, engraving and rock art show growing symbolic and artistic expression.

10. Fire and Its Importance

Controlled fire was a major technological development. It provided warmth, light and protection and allowed humans to cook food.

Cooking made food easier to eat and digest and helped humans survive in different environments.

11. Mesolithic Age – Middle Stone Age

The Mesolithic was a transitional phase between the Palaeolithic and Neolithic. After the last Ice Age, warmer conditions led humans to adapt to new environments.

People continued hunting and gathering, while fishing and collecting wild plants became important in many areas.

Microliths were small stone tools that could be fixed into wood or bone to make composite tools.

Mesolithic communities used temporary or semi-permanent settlements in many regions.

Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh is an important Indian site known for prehistoric rock art.

12. Neolithic Age – New Stone Age

The Neolithic brought a major change from food gathering to food production.

People began agriculture and animal domestication and increasingly lived in permanent settlements.

Major features included polished stone tools, pottery, weaving, food storage, farming and herding.

13. Neolithic Revolution

The Neolithic Revolution refers to the gradual transition from hunting and gathering to agriculture and animal domestication. It was not a single sudden event and occurred at different times in different regions.

Broad sequence: **Agriculture** → **food surplus** → **population growth** → **permanent settlements** → **specialised occupations** → **trade** → **towns** → **cities** → **civilisation**.

Farming brought benefits such as a more dependable food supply, surplus production and settled life, but also challenges such as hard labour, crop failure, disease, dependence on climate and the need to protect crops and animals.

14. Domestication of Animals

Domestication is the gradual process through which humans controlled, bred and raised selected animals for their use.

Animals provided meat, milk, hides, labour, transport and manure and became an important part of settled agricultural life.

15. Mehrgarh

Mehrgarh, near the Bolan River in present-day Pakistan, is one of the earliest known farming settlements of the Indian subcontinent, dating to around 7000 BCE.

People cultivated wheat and barley, domesticated sheep and goats, and raised zebu cattle.

They lived in mud-brick houses, stored food, made ornaments and used stone and other materials for tools.

By around 4000 BCE, copper objects were being made, marking Chalcolithic developments.

16. Chalcolithic Age

Chalcolithic means Copper-Stone Age. It was a period when copper was used along with stone tools.

Remember: Chalcolithic = Copper + Stone; Bronze Age = Bronze, mainly an alloy of copper and tin.

17. From Villages to Civilisation

As agriculture developed, settlements became larger and more permanent.

Food surplus meant that not everyone had to farm. Some people became craftsmen, traders, builders, administrators, priests or soldiers.

This occupational specialisation increased economic and social complexity and helped towns and cities develop.

18. Sindhu-Sarasvati Civilisation

The Sindhu-Sarasvati civilisation, also called the Harappan or Indus Valley Civilisation, was a major Bronze Age civilisation of the Indian subcontinent.

It developed around the Indus and Sarasvati/Ghaggar-Sarasvati river systems and grew from earlier Neolithic and Chalcolithic communities.

19. Features of the Harappan Civilisation

Planned cities: Organised streets, planned settlements, brick structures and specialised areas.

Water management: Sophisticated collection, storage and management of water. Dholavira is especially famous for reservoirs and water-management systems.

Standardised weights and measures: Supported trade, exchange and economic organisation.

Seals: Often made of stone and bearing animal motifs and inscriptions; they likely had administrative and commercial uses.

Craft production: Skilled bead-making, pottery, shell work, metalworking and stone working.

20. Harappan Agriculture and Script

At Kalibangan, fields with crossing furrows have been interpreted as evidence of double-crop cultivation, comparable in a broad sense to seasonal Rabi and Kharif patterns.

The Harappans used a pictographic script on seals, pottery and other objects.

Most important: The Harappan script remains undeciphered. Therefore, material evidence is especially important for reconstructing Harappan life.

21. Bronze Age Civilisations

Three other major Bronze Age civilisations discussed with the Harappans are Mesopotamia, Egypt and China.

Mesopotamia: Tigris and Euphrates.

Egypt: Nile.

China: Huang He (Yellow River) and later other major river regions including the Yangtze.

River valleys provided water, fertile soil, agricultural opportunities, transport and trade routes.

22. Mesopotamian Civilisation

Mesopotamia is a Greek term meaning 'land between the rivers', referring to the region between the Tigris and Euphrates.

The **Fertile Crescent** was a crescent-shaped fertile region of West Asia favourable for early agriculture.

The Sumerians developed early city-based civilisation in southern Mesopotamia. Important cities included Ur and Uruk.

They developed irrigation, canals, mud/baked brick construction, cities, cuneiform writing and ziggurats.

Ziggurat: A large stepped temple structure associated with the religious and economic life of a Mesopotamian city.

23. Mesopotamian Trade and Kingdoms

Mesopotamia developed extensive trade networks. Records mention Dilmun (associated with Bahrain), Magan (associated with Oman) and Meluhha (generally associated with the Harappan region).

Akkadians: Sargon established a powerful empire.

Assyrians: Became powerful in northern Mesopotamia; Assur was an important centre.

Babylonians: Babylon became a major centre; Hammurabi was a famous ruler.

Code of Hammurabi: A collection of laws showing organised legal rules and administration.

24. Egyptian Civilisation

Ancient Egyptian civilisation developed along the Nile. The river provided water, fertile soil, transport and agricultural opportunities.

Regular Nile flooding helped agriculture flourish.

Hieroglyphics was the Egyptian writing system. **Papyrus** was used as a writing material.

The **Rosetta Stone** played an important role in deciphering hieroglyphics. In 1822, Jean-François Champollion made the breakthrough in decipherment.

Egyptian society was hierarchical, with the Pharaoh at the top, followed by officials/nobles/priests, farmers/artisans/merchants and labouring groups.

Belief in the afterlife encouraged practices such as mummification and the construction of tombs and pyramids.

25. Chinese Civilisation

Early Chinese civilisation developed especially around the Huang He (Yellow River) and later other major river regions including the Yangtze.

Agricultural communities existed in China from the Neolithic period. Copper and bronze metallurgy contributed to Bronze Age development.

Shang Dynasty (c. 1600–1046 BCE): Associated with bronze technology, cities, ritual vessels and oracle-bone inscriptions.

Zhou Dynasty (1046–256 BCE): Another major political power. By around 600 BCE, iron use had become widespread in China.

Ancient Chinese people were skilled in bronze-making, jade-working, pottery, weaving and silk production.

26. Silk and Long-Distance Trade

Silk production was known in ancient China and later became an important trade commodity.

The network of routes through which silk and other goods travelled over long distances became known as the **Silk Route**.

27. Why Civilisations Developed Near Rivers?

River valleys supported early civilisations because they offered fertile soil, reliable water, transport, food production and trade opportunities.

Key chain: **River → agriculture → food surplus → population growth → occupational specialisation → trade → towns/cities → civilisation.**

28. Interaction Between Early Civilisations

Early civilisations were not completely isolated. Strong evidence exists for interaction between Mesopotamia and the Sindhu-Sarasvati civilisation.

Mesopotamian records refer to **Meluhha**, generally associated with the Harappan region. Trade likely involved beads, ivory, timber, precious materials, metals and other craft goods.

Evidence for direct contact between the Sindhu-Sarasvati civilisation and ancient Egypt or China is much less direct.

29. Similarities Among Early Civilisations

Major early civilisations shared agriculture, permanent settlements, specialised occupations, trade, social hierarchy, religious institutions, technologies and administrative systems.

However, each civilisation developed its own distinctive culture, institutions and technologies.

30. Complete Flow: Stone Age to Civilisation

Early human ancestors → tool-making → Palaeolithic hunter-gatherers → Mesolithic adaptation and microliths → Neolithic agriculture/domestication → permanent villages → food surplus → population growth and occupational specialisation → Chalcolithic copper technology → Bronze Age → towns and cities → writing, administration and trade → civilisation.

Important Comparisons

Palaeolithic	Mesolithic	Neolithic
Old Stone Age	Middle Stone Age	New Stone Age
Mainly hunter-gatherers	Hunter-gatherers with new adaptations	Farmers and herders
Large/chipped tools	Microliths	Polished stone tools
Mostly mobile	Temporary/semi-permanent settlements	Permanent settlements
Hunting and gathering	Hunting, fishing and gathering	Agriculture and domestication

Four Major River-Valley Civilisations

Civilisation	Main river/region	Famous writing/feature
Sindhu-Sarasvati	Indus and Sarasvati/Ghaggar-Sarasvati	Harappan script; undeciphered; planned cities
Mesopotamia	Tigris and Euphrates	Cuneiform; ziggurats
Egypt	Nile	Hieroglyphics; pyramids and mummification
China	Huang He and Yangtze regions	Early Chinese writing; bronze technology

Important Dates

Date/Period	Event
c. 3.3 million years ago	Early stone tools
c. 2 million years ago	Homo erectus and early migration out of Africa
c. 300,000 years ago	Homo sapiens evolved in Africa
c. 125,000 years ago	Major later migration of Homo sapiens out of Africa
c. 7000 BCE	Mehrgarh farming settlement
c. 4000 BCE	Copper objects / Chalcolithic developments
c. 3200 BCE	Early Mesopotamian writing/cuneiform
c. 2600 BCE	Mature phase of Harappan civilisation
c. 1600 BCE	Shang Bronze Age period in China
3rd century BCE	Brahmi prominent in Ashokan inscriptions
1822 CE	Champollion's decipherment breakthrough for Egyptian hieroglyphics

Important Terms – Quick Revision

Archaeology: Study of the human past through material remains.

Artefact: An object made or modified by humans and left as evidence of past activity.

Hominin: Modern humans and their early human-like ancestors.

Palaeolithic: Old Stone Age; mainly hunter-gatherer life and chipped stone tools.

Mesolithic: Middle Stone Age; microliths and changing hunter-gatherer adaptations.

Neolithic: New Stone Age; agriculture, domestication and permanent settlements.

Neolithic Revolution: Gradual transition from hunting/gathering to agriculture and animal domestication.

Chalcolithic: Copper-Stone Age; copper used along with stone.

Bronze Age: Period when bronze became an important material; bronze is mainly copper + tin.

Civilisation: Complex society with agriculture/surplus, specialised occupations, organised settlements, administration, trade and often writing.

Cuneiform: Early Mesopotamian writing system.

Hieroglyphics: Pictorial writing system of ancient Egypt.

Ziggurat: Large stepped temple structure in ancient Mesopotamia.

■ Five Must-Remember Points

- Africa was the major centre of early human evolution.
- Homo erectus is associated with an early major migration out of Africa.
- Neolithic Revolution = agriculture + animal domestication + settled life.
- Harappan script is still undeciphered.
- The four major river-valley civilisations discussed are Sindhu-Sarasvati, Mesopotamian, Egyptian and Chinese.

One-Minute Revision

Africa → Hominins → Tools → Stone Age → Palaeolithic → Mesolithic → Neolithic → Agriculture → Domestication → Villages → Surplus → Chalcolithic → Bronze Age → Cities → Writing → Civilisation

River Civilisations: Sindhu-Sarasvati → Indus/Sarasvati; Mesopotamia → Tigris/Euphrates; Egypt → Nile; China → Huang He.